

front of the double pivot in the midfield — for most of 2023, Ashique's injury will see Naorem Mahesh take up the spot along the left, with Sahal playing the No. 10 role.

Anirudh Thapa is expected to orchestrate attacks from the midfield, but India will have to dig deep to find options for the defensive midfield role, with Jeakson ruled out.

Though Lalengmawia Ralte and Suresh Singh will be the preferred options for Stimac, a narrow-attacking approach by a more physical team — which is the case with all three opponents — can leave India bitterly exposed when out of possession.

However, Stimac's biggest headache will be the No. 9.

While Chhetri, India's highest goalscorer of all time, has owned that position for the last decade, age will be a huge factor — he is 39 — against physical teams from India's group.

It is this position that might see a youngster find his own 'Subrata Paul moment' in the Asian Cup, filling in the boots of a legend.

Ishan Pandita and Manvir Singh, both of whom have played as No. 9 before, will have their trials by fire for this spot in Doha.

Asian Cup favourite

The AFC Asian Cup will be the perfect opportunity for host Qatar to recover from the wounds of the FIFA World Cup on home soil in 2022. The Asian champion became the worst-performing host in World Cup history after losing all its games, conceding seven goals, and getting knocked out.

It has changed two managers since and will hope to defend its crown under former Espanyol manager Tintin Marquez, with stern competition from Japan, Iran, South Korea, and Australia.

Qatar will look for goals from its most dependable forward, Almoez Ali, who has been equally adept in

front and along the wings.

Almoez, the Golden Boot winner in the last edition of the tournament, holds the record for most goals in a single edition of the Asian Cup (nine goals) and has become more threatening under former Paris Saint-Germain manager Christophe Galtier at Al Duhail.

Japan, the most successful team

Leading by example: India captain Sunil Chhetri, at 39, will once again be the key striker for his team at the AFC Asian Cup. AIFF MEDIA

in the competition (four titles), was the giant killer in the FIFA World Cup 2022, beating former world champions Germany and Spain. Winger Kaoru Mitoma, who had suffered an ankle injury, has made the cut and will be key for Japan, which enters the event as the highest-ranked Asian side.

South Korea, on the other hand, will look to make the most of the European experience of its players, with 12 out of 26 playing professionally in Europe. Tottenham's Son Heung-Min, who has been in fine goal-scoring touch in the Premier League, will hope to inspire South Korea, runner-up in 2015, to bag the top honour.

So India has its task cut out. It may lack depth, but so did Morocco, playing against then-World No. 2 Belgium, Cristiano Ronaldo's Portugal, and the 2010 World Champion Spain — opponents it persevered against and won at the 2022 FIFA World Cup.

Stimac's India would look to take a leaf out of the same book to pull off the perfect underdog success story.

